Salazar stays quiet. "Yeah, I do want to take this omulet from them."

"What's an omulet?"

"Amulet," Salazar corrects himself. "Do you think you can help me get it? I know you're a proficient thief - "

The rogue raises an eyebrow. "You want me to take it for you secretly? Isn't that kind of going against my advice of talking to them about it?"

"I will," Salazar says. "But if it doesn't work out..."

Vilde nods. "If that doesn't work out, you can tell me and I'll you take it."

Salazar returns to his room, collecting his thoughts. Working up his courage, the wizard heads off to find Wang Lei.

"Don't mind me," Salazar says. "I saw previously you were talking to Raphael about an amulet of some kind, and I overheard my name. Do you mind telling me more about the amulet? How is it related to me?"

"I cannot tell you anything," Wang Lei says plainly. "And to be honest, I don't know actually. But let me just tell you this. I can cast *Protection from Good and Evil* on you, so nothing bad will happen to you."

Salazar scrutinizes the warlock's face, but finds nothing.

"I specifically heard that this amulet is meant for me," Salazar continues. "And then you passed it to Raphael? Is that supposed to protect me?"

"No, no," Wang Lei explains. "I will be the one that protects you."

"Then why did you pass it to Raphael?"

"It was to help me check," Wang Lei explains. "He is much better at these arcane matters than me, and I wanted to see if there was anything special about the amulet - "

"And what did he say?"

"He said there was nothing that concerns us," Wang Lei replies.

"Okay, I will take your word for it," The wizard replies. "To be frank, I am quite scared of what I will become. If you know of any truth about what is to come, or who I am, you have to let me know - "

"I cannot," Wang Lei says. "But I am not here to harm you."

Salazar nods. Still suspicious of the warlock, and knowing that he will gain no further answers here, the wizard heads off to find Raphael.

"Yo, Raphael," Salazar enters the sorcerer's room, shutting the door behind him. "I know that this is on me, and that I shouldn't be sneaking around, but I did see you pass an amulet to Wang Lei outside the tent. Does that concern me? He was being a bit dodgy when I questioned him about it."

"Your past is also dodgy," Raphael replies. "Don't you know that?"

"I do," Salazar replies. "That's why I'm trying to figure out how is this amulet related to me."

"I think for the safety of everybody," Raphael offers. "We should all just come clean and try to seek answers together as a Party - "

"I couldn't agree more," Salazar asks. "That's why I shared about the dream I had with Acererak."

"I think we are similar, you know," Raphael says, looking at the wizard. "Despite our differences, we can both potentially harm the Party. We are going to fight the person that created you, so I think it's natural that people are going to have their guard around you. But regarding my conversation with Wang Lei... that is not my secret to tell."

Salazar stays quiet, thinking. He sees Wang Lei's insistence at protecting the secret, and suspects that perhaps the warlock is in a difficult position and cannot reveal what he knows. Salazar thanks the sorcerer before heading off politely.

The wizard does not return to his room. Instead, he heads to Vilde's, who raises an eyebrow at Salazar's approach.

"I've spoken to both of them," Salazar says, steeling himself. "I'm going to need your help."

Fraying Bonds

Wukong. As you sit by the fire, eating your meal quietly, Thaisha sits down next to you.

"Hey," the druid says. "How was your day?"

"Well, let's see," Wukong says. "We fought some grungs and we fought some Red Wizards, and we only got two cubes."

"Do you remember our conversation previously?" the half-orc asks quietly. "The one before we returned to Camp Vengeance, where I told you to protect Hazel?"

Wukong nods.

"It's been a busy couple of weeks," Thaisha confesses. "And... admittedly, with the Senator's death, our priorities have shifted considerably. Which is fair, right?

If I was in Vilde's shoes... I would like the Party to help." Thaisha stares into the crackling campfire, thinking. "I have had some time to think, and to be very honest, I believe that Raphael is no longer interested in Opening the Gate. I don't think we need to worry about him for now. But..." Thaisha pauses. "Do you believe that Salazar is a clone of Acererak?"

"We can't rule out that it is a possibility," Wukong says evenly. "But, even if he is a clone, we have to think about whether or not he's a threat to us. He is *not* Acererak."

"I agree," Thaisha says. "He is not Acererak. But you must see the danger. For all we know, Acererak could be spying on us through him. That is a problem for which we have no solution," Thaisha looks at Wukong. "I'm not saying I have a solution, of course. I don't want to kill him. He's a friend, even if he is a little weird." The druid sighs, staring back into the fire.

"To be frank with you, I don't think our Party is made up of good people," Thaisha continues. "Sir Wang Lei... I used to think he was an upstanding knight, but now I see that he cares for little other than power. You weren't there, but after we caught up with Percival in the bell tower, instead of going up to interrogate the captive or check to see if Vilde was alright, he strolled over to loot the man's weapons." A dark look crossed her face. "And of course, Raphael's Raphael, and now even Salazar — "

A voice rings out from your *Sending Stone*.

"Found my father. I am back at Camp Vengeance now," Yandala's voice is crystal clear through the stone. "Where are you guys? Met a simian called Liu, he is looking for you Wukong — "

The voice cuts out abruptly, leaving Thaisha and Wukong astonished and amazed by the firelight.

Vilde. We return to the moment of Salazar asking a favor from you.

"I could help," Vilde sits up from her bed, staring at Salazar. "But I'll need something in return."

"Anything," the wizard pleads.

"Number one, when we fight the Hags, protect me," Vilde says.

Salazar shrugs. "That is the least I could do."

Vilde pauses, sizing up the wizard. *Could she trust him with her secrets?* "Number two, support me, even when I do something suspicious."

The wizard narrows his eyes.

"What you're doing now is suspicious, by the way," the rogue points out. "And I'm willing to do it for you. The least you can do is to support me."

"We have a deal."

Downstairs, Wang Lei calls out to the group to gather in the stables. He quickly explains that the *Protection from Evil and Good* spell is concentration and lasts for ten minutes only, meaning that some one would have to keep vigil throughout the night. He volunteers to stay up and watch the Party for any signs of a nightmare attack for tonight, but explains that it is likely that he would be exhausted the following day.

"It is a temporary measure," Wang Lei explains. "We got three cubes in a day, so I think if we keep this up, it may only require a day or two."

"There's more," Wukong replies. "I received a message from our good friend Yandala."

Vilde scoffs. "Good friend?"

"She's still alive," the simian continues, relief in his voice.

"That's great news," Salazar says. "I'm glad the frost giants didn't get her." The wizard shoots a look at Vilde, who shrugs.

"I knew she would evade them."

"She found her father, and she's back at Camp Vengeance," Wukong continues. "But remember our interaction with Arthur? I think something's not right."

Intelligence (History) Check

On a successful DC **15** check, Wukong remembers that he did not tell Yandala about Liu, one of his acolytes at Huaguoshan. He comes to the conclusion that the only reason she would have known anything about him is that they have actually met.

"Do you trust her?" asks Vilde.

"I am suspicious," Wukong replies. "But I will Send back a message."

"We could always meet her at a neutral ground," offers Thaisha. "If we're worried. Maybe at a shrine, or something?"

"I don't think we need more people on the Expedition, to be honest," Vilde says dryly. "How do we even know its her?"

Wukong shrugs. "We can decide this tomorrow, when we get more information."

The Party nods, concluding the discussion. They break

up, heading back to their rooms. Wukong retrieves his *Sending Stone* and drafts his response. Still unsure if she could be trusted, he says, "I'm glad you found your father. How's your interaction with your father? How do you know Liu? We are currently very far away, finishing mission."

Returning upstairs, Vilde pulls Salazar aside. "Do you know where's the amulet?"

"The last time I saw it, it was with Wang Lei."

Vilde rolls her eyes. "Where? On his body? In his bag?"

"It was with him," says Salazar.

Vilde sighs, walking away. The rogue stealthily creeps down back into the stable, approaching the paladin quietly.

Dexterity (Stealth) Check
On a contested DC **20** check, Vilde successfully sneaks up on Wang Lei.

Intelligence (Investigation) Check
On a DC **15** check, Vilde does not find it on Wang Lei's person.

Suspecting that it is in the paladin's room, Vilde heads up to find it. She thoroughly rummages through all of his belongings, intent on finding this amulet.

Intelligence (Investigation) Check
On a Natural **20** check, Vilde does not find it in his room.

Suspicion fills Vilde's mind. Certain that she had performed a thorough search, she starts to wonder: where had the paladin gone after his conversation with Raphael outside the tent? Prior to the paladin gathering everybody and explaining his offer to stay up and cast *Protection from Evil and Good,* he was briefly unaccounted for. She concludes that he must have had passed it off to somebody else in the time he disappeared.

Could it have been Raphael? The rogue briefly wondered, but quickly dismissed. *It's too simple, if it was. He'd known that was the next suspect.*

Vilde skulks off silently, heading to Salazar's room. With a quick knock, she enters the wizard's domicile.

"I tried to find it on his body and his room," Vilde continues. "It's not there. I think he must have passed it off to someone." The rogue watches the wizard intently. "I know what you're thinking, it's not Raphael. It would be too simple if it was. Maybe... it's with you?"

"It's definitely not me," Salazar says. "I wouldn't have gone through this charade with you, if I had it already."

Intelligence (Investigation) Check
Failing a DC **20** check, Vilde does not find it in Salazar's room.

Vilde starts tossing Salazar's stuff around, trying to confirm her hypothesis.

"What are you doing?!" The wizard protests. "Hey, that's my bed!"

"Your memory is really bad, I'm just helping you find it," Vilde says plainly. After ten minutes of causing a ruckus, she gives up. "I guess it's not here."

"You don't say," replies Salazar.

"Well it ain't you, it ain't me, and it ain't Raphael."

"And it ain't Wang Lei," Salazar continues.

Vilde shrugs. "Okay, that's all. I'm going to sleep."

Salazar ponders the situation. Realizing that the Party is huge, he could have theoretically given it to anybody. "Wait a minute. Did you check Khan and Vorn?"

"There's only so many things I can do," Vilde says, rolling her eyes. "Besides, they don't have pockets. It'd be incredibly obvious if they have it."

"It's fine," Salazar replies, yawning. "We can try again tomorrow."

"Yeah, okay," Vilde says. "Maybe you can try talking to some people, see if they know anything."

Salazar nods.

In the privacy of his own room, Raphael pens his letters. He quickly drafts a statement to the Inspector Harondus Eisensturm, detailing Kaelen's attack on Camp Vengeance that led to the Castellan Lyara Porter's death.

He then turns his attention to the pressing matter. Afraid that House Eisensturm may move against House Antarra, the sorcerer pens a letter back home.

"Investigations into the Gate has concluded that it is related to some elder god," Raphael writes. "This information was also discovered by House Eisensturm. Do what you must with this. The mission in Kroonstad is about to end." He quickly mails off the letters before heading to try and get some shuteye in the stables.

Despite what Vilde said to Salazar, the rogue stealthily heads off to find Percival. The gunslinger, returning from outside the tent, looks frantic.

"Something the matter?"

"It's Orym," Percival replies. "He's not replying me."

"Where does the river lead?" Vilde asks.

"I think it leads straight into the lava pit," Percival replies.

"Maybe you shouldn't have pushed him in then," the rogue mutters.

"Anything could have happened to him," Percival says. "He could have been captured by the kobolds, he could be — "

Vilde puts a reassuring hand on his shoulder. "Don't worry. It's dark out. We can't find him now, but tomorrow morning we can do a fly over and find him."

"We had a plan," Percival explains. "We were supposed to meet in the bell tower in the western quarter as a safehouse. If he made it out of the river, that's where he'll be, but it's weird he hasn't replied."

"He might have lost it in the river," offers Vilde. "You never know. We're going there anyway, so it's fine."

Percival nods grimly.

"I just wanted to check in with you, these... ranged weapons you have," Vilde says. "They have a name?"

"Yeah," the gunslinger replies. "They're called guns. The larger one is a sniper, while the smaller one is a pepperbox pistol."

"Do you have the blueprints for them?"

Percival nods, producing his *Book of Shadows*. Vilde thumbs through them, reading the book. She finds intricate drawings, recipes for mixing blackpowder and all sorts of occult knowledge that the Hags had provided him.

"Do you mind if I hold on to this for a minute?" The rogue asks. "Just wanted to learn about them, if I can."

Percival nods. "You want to make one of your own?"

"I think they are a new technology," she says. "Would be good to keep my city safe."

"Any artificer worth his salt would be able to make one of these, if they had the right knowledge," the gunslinger continues. "I'm not a learned man, which is why I had to be a warlock to them to be able to understand the knowledge, but someone in the craft would be able to replicate the stuff in here to make guns, no problem."

Intelligence (History) Check
On a successful DC **15** check, Vilde remembers Captain Jarlaxle.

Vilde considers the implication. She remembers about the swashbuckler they had met the first time they were passing through Camp Vengeance, who had the pistol with their names engraved on it. The rogue realizes that anybody with that pistol would be able to replicate the research and make their own.

"By any chance," Vilde says. "We met a drow swashbuckler near Camp Vengeance a few weeks back. He had a pistol. Do you... know anything about him?"

"No, not really. But if he had a pistol..." Percival's voice trails off. "I used to be a thief in the Xanathar Network, and worked for a person called Florinna — "

"I'm aware," Vilde murmurs.

"You've met her?"

Vilde nods. "Briefly."

"We were ambushed by a woman with a greatsword," Percival explains. "She had a tattoo on her chin. Near one of the rivers near the Revolutionary Guard camp. I lost one of my pistols then, the first one I had created. During the battle, we had to break contact. Last I saw Florinna, she was unconscious."

"Did you recognize the tattoo?" Vilde continues. "Like maybe she's from a tribe or something — "

Percival shook his head. "Didn't recognize it. But I will tell you this, woman was a barbarian. Had a mean left hook."

"Any other distinguishing characteristics? Like her race —"

"Aasimar?" Percival shrugs. "Could have been goliath, too."

"So she's huge?"

"Kind of slim, actually," the gunslinger replies. "But she was crazy strong."

"If Florinna survived, where do you think she would have gone?"

"No clue," Percival replies. "I highly doubt it. Like I said, she was unconscious the last time I saw her."

Vilde nods grimly. "Okay, thank you for the blueprints. Please keep them to yourself, and don't share them with anyone else. Dangerous. Dangerous objects. Very dangerous."

Vilde goes back to her room. Using her *Sending Stone,* she sends a message to her father Angwyn. "Reached Raya," Vilde assures. "On track to saving Mummy. Positive thoughts and feelings. Will be sending blueprints, get a good artificer on it. We will save Nike." She traces the blueprints, before heading out of the tent to mail it back on a raven.

Taking heed of Vilde's suggestion, Salazar heads to Hazel's room. Fully naked and in the middle of a mud facial, the rabbitfolk greets the wizard. "Yes?"

"I, uh, hope I'm not interrupting you," Salazar starts. "I can drop by five minutes later, if you'd like."

"No, it's fine," Hazel says.

"Quick question, then," Salazar continues. "Did you happen to chance upon, or been handed over, a jewelry, which I can't go into too much detail — "

"No?"

Wisdom (Insight) Check
On a successful DC **15** check, Salazar deduces that she is likely telling the truth.

"Okay, good chat," replies the wizard. Salazar returns to his room, frustrated by the events of the last few days. As he sits down in his room, he sees the book Professor McGonagall had given him so long ago. *Had she known who he was this whole time?*

Salazar gets up to his table, and does what he does best. He writes. He makes it halfway through the letter, before crumpling the parchment up and throwing it away. He starts a new letter again, this time trying to keep his anger at the Professor tempered.

"Acererak reached out to me," The wizard's usually neat penmanship, twisted by fear and anger, is now a twisted scrawl. "He says I am his clone. Did you know? Is that the reason why you gave me the book?"

A pang of guilt strangles his guts, overpowering the cocktail of fear and anger. *Was he responsible for all the death and misery brought about by the Devourer? Was there even anything he could do?*

Salazar takes a deep breath. As a quiet calm settles over the wizard, his handwriting resumes to his usual tidiness. "How do I beat him?"

With clarity returning to his mind, he decides to replicate the letter, sending them to the Ring of Silver and the Ring of Gold as well. He also seeks more knowledge about simulacrums and clones, asking his more learned peers if it is even possible for himself to gain free will.

Finishing his letter, the wizard seals his letters. As he does so, he finds the *Talisman of the Sphere* buried beneath a mountain of letters, open books and other stationery.

"Looks like Vilde came through, after all," Salazar thinks. He picks up the amulet, inspecting it. He sticks his head out of the door, trying to see if there was anyone in the corridor. Satisfied that he is alone, the wizard heads over to Vilde's room, intending to thank the rogue for her favor.

Finding it empty, Salazar decides to thank her tomorrow morning. He returns to his room, inspecting the *Talisman of the Sphere*. He learns of its properties, and its magical ability to help spellcasters control a *Sphere of Annihilation*.

Intelligence (History) Check
On a successful DC **15** check, Salazar recalls that Acererak has a *Sphere of Annihilation*.

As the wizard examines the amulet, he sees that the green jewels embedded in the eyes of the tribal mask pendant has dark shadows swirling. As he leans in, cracks appear in the jewels as two wraiths explode out.

> Even amongst the shifting shadows you recognize the wraiths: both of them are wearing the face of Ayo.



Wraith

Medium Undead, Neutral Evil

Armor Class 13
Hit Points 67 (9d8 + 27)
Speed 5 ft., Fly 60 ft.

STR	DEX	CON	INT	WIS	CHA
6 (-2)	16 (+3)	16 (+3)	12 (+1)	14 (+2)	15 (+2)

Skills NIL
Damage Resistances Acid, Bludgeoning, Cold, Fire, Piercing, Slashing
Damage Immunities Necrotic, Poison
Condition Immunities Charmed, Exhaustion, Grappled, Paralyzed, Petrified, Poisoned, Prone, Restrained, Unconscious
Senses Darkvision 60 ft, Passive Perception 12
Languages Common **Initiative Bonus** +3

Traits

Incorporeal Movement. The wraith can move through other creatures and objects as if they were Difficult Terrain. It takes and deals 5 Force damage if it ends its turn inside an object.

Sunlight Sensitivity. While in sunlight, the wraith has Disadvantage on ability checks and attack rolls.

Actions

Life Drain. *Melee Attack Roll*: +6, reach 5 ft. *Hit*: 21 (4d8 +3) Necrotic damage. In addition, if the target is a creature, the creature is Grappled, its Hit Point maximum decreases by an amount equal to half of the damage taken.

Bonus Actions

Create Specter. The wraith targets a Humanoid corpse within 10 feet of itself that has been dead for no longer than 1 minute. The target's spirit rises as a Specter in the space of its corpse or in the nearest unoccupied space. The specter is under the wraith's control. The wraith can have no more than seven specters under its control at a time.

Salazar drops the amulet in shock, instinctively casting *Misty Step* to create distance between himself and the vengeful undead. He leaps off the stairwell, landing at the first floor of the Commanders' Tent with surprising grace.

"Ayo!" Salazar screams. "Ayo! Ayo! She's back! There's two of her!" He clambers towards the stable, rallying the Party.

Having just sent off her letter, Vilde re-enters the tent. She scrambles forward towards the wizard, using the smoke from the campfire as concealment. She draws *Sprezzatura,* pulling back its string. A magical green arrow twists into reality as the rogue readies her arrow at the stairwell.

Raphael leaps up from his resting place in the stable, rushing out towards the campfire. He keeps his eyes open, ready to dodge any sudden strikes.

The wraiths, still on the second floor, phase harmlessly through the floorboards. Reappearing in the stable, they split up, attempting to drift incorporeally through the crowd gathered in the stables towards their quarry.

Vilde unleashes a nocked arrow, sinking it deep in one of the wraiths. Unbothered, it dives straight through Wukong's chest, appearing on the other side with supernatural celerity. The stalwart paladin swings his *Jingubang* instinctively, the divine weapon striking true. Wukong stuns one of the wraith, sending its misty form careening into Vorn. Where the undead should strike the shield guardian, it instead vanishes into Vorn's chest.

The other screaming wraith lunges towards Salazar, ignoring glancing blows from Hazel and Thaisha. The paladin, mace charged with godly power, swings a vicious blow at the undead's head, stunning the other wraith and stopping it in its tracks.

Unfortunately, Wang Lei was a step too late. Despite being unable to move, the predator found its prey. In a powerful scream, the wraith begins draining life from the wizard.

Ariadne raises her *Staff of Healing,* casting *Cure Wounds* on the battered Salazar. She then disappears in a cloud of mist, as the wizard *Misty Step*s across the campfire.

Joining Ariadne, Hazel mutters a powerful *Healing Word.* A rushing smell of fungus fills the air as brilliant blue light surges through Salazar's body, mending the damage. She strides forward, summoning a *Thorn Whip* and lashing at the wraith in front of Salazar.

From behind Hazel, a streak of light soars overhead, blasting the screaming wraith. Thaisha's *Guiding Bolt* leaves the wraith attacking Salazar in glittering golden light, marking it for all to see.

Salazar, refreshed from the healing magic, screams, "You're not real! Begone!" Tapping into a newfound level of power, the wizard casts *Banishment.* Green light swirls around the wraith, attempting to send it away.

"No," the undead speaks with a raspy voice, resisting the spell. "You killed me."

Yelping, the wizard stumbles backwards. His mind reaches out in abject fear, shoving the wraith backwards. The undead spirit tumbles backwards, crashing to the ground.

Wang Lei strides forward, slamming his mace down in a powerful blow of thunder and divine light. Power

erupts violently from contact, dissipating the wraith with no mercy.

Percival draws his pistol *Vengeance*, unloading three quick shots into the last wraith. Vorn's hands scratch harmlessly at his chest, hoping to find the wraith that had vanished into it. He lumbers forward, swinging a powerful backhand to slap the wraith.

Mason steels his eyes at the last wraith. His *Javelin of Lightning* crackles with electricity as the squire leaps up, driving the weapon right into the wraith's heart. Leaving behind nothing but a scream, the wraith explodes as the powerful current disintegrates the undead.

"Time to sleep," Salazar mumbles, rubbing his eyes.

"What was that?" Wukong cursed.

"Excuse me, sleep?" Vilde marches forward to Salazar, her eyes boring into him. "We just almost died."

"Explain, please," Thaisha demands, eyeing the wizard. "What the hells was that?"

"Good question," Salazar replies. "Beats me."

"There were two Ayos," Vilde pointed out. "Did you see them? They said you killed them?"

"Where did they come from?" Wukong pressed.

"I don't know," Salazar says, his flippant attitude highly suspicious. "These wraiths... they can't be trusted."

Wukong rolls his eyes, casting *Zone of Truth*.

Schemes of the Yuan-Ti

As Wukong casts *Zone of Truth,* all of you watch slithering into the tent are twelve Yuan-Ti. Leading them is a human male with the back half of snakes as tentacles for arms, who step forward.

"Um, hi sir," Wukong says, eyeing the group. "Please visit us another day. We're busy here."

"I am Merrshaulk," the yuan-ti explains, looking at the group. "I come as an emissary for the great warlord Ras Nsi. May I ask, who is your leader?"

"Yes?" Vilde steps forward, confronting the group. "What's up?"

Merrshaulk shoots the elf a quizzical look, drawing her scorn.

"Are you not a feminist?" She presses. "Do you think girls cannot be leaders?"

Raising his tentacles in surprise, Merrshaulk simply replies, "Hey man, I didn't say any of that. I am deeply in support of the feminist cause - "



"Great, because this is a feminist expedition," Vilde says plainly.

"We are all allies," agrees Wukong.

"The great Ras Nsi has noticed your presence," Merrshaulk continues, regaining his composure. "And more importantly, your effectiveness. Our patrols report that you have three cubes already. He wishes to speak to powerful adventurers like yourselves. Propose a deal."

"Where is he situated?"

"The Fane of the Night Serpent, below the city," Merrshaulk replies. "Follow us, and we will bring you to him."

"Great," Vilde says. "We'll meet him tomorrow. As you would understand, we want to prepare ourselves before we meet such an esteemed individual."

"Well, my orders are much simpler," Merrshaulk replies. "Either you come with us now to meet him, or we take all of you by force."

Vilde raises an eyebrow. "Are you sure you want to fight us?"

Wisdom (Perception) Check
On a successful DC **15** check, the Party sees through the open flap of the Commanders' Tent that there is an additional dozen of yuan-ti warriors outside.

"Yes," Merrshaulk says plainly. "To assauge your fears, I am happy to report that it is a peace meeting. You are free to bring all of your weapons and equipment, although not all of you may come. Yes, I think four is a suitable number, of course including yourself."

"Fine," Vilde says. "Give us a few minutes, and then we will head out."

Raphael, Vilde, Wukong and Vorn, volunteering as delegates, chooses to attend the meeting. Afraid that they might be robbed, they leave behind the puzzle cubes.

Stepping into the cool night air, Raphael casts *Rary's Telepathic Bond*.

"To be fair, he didn't ask us to bring the cubes," Wukong pointed out psychically.

"And he did say he comes in peace," replies Vilde. "Maybe it will be chill."

"Yeah, I would take that with a pinch of salt," warned Raphael. "How many times have you seen people say they 'come in peace,' only to then attack?"

Merrshaulk leads the way, with the rest of the squadron of yuan-ti following behind. After about thirty minutes of walking, you realize that he is leading you back to the Royal Palace. Soon, all of you arrive at a place Raphael and Wukong both recognize. A worked tunnel descending into the earth here, with familiar muddy cart-tracks.

As you head down into the tunnel, you see a wide passage sloping down to a set of bronze doors. Coiled serpents decorate the metal, with a sliding hatch at head height. Four-inch-wide holes form a gap at the base of each door.

"Nahth," Merrshaulk orders. "Open the gates."

As it slides open, you see pits covered with iron grates. Stepping over it, all of you watch a swarm of poisonous snakes writhing in the hole.

Entering the passageway, you see four pillars carved with serpent reliefs supporting the room. In the center of the chamber is a towering 18-foot-tall statue of a terrifying serpent. A multi-headed Yuan-ti anathema, chiseled from dark, weathered basalt, the massive, muscular serpent dominates the room. Its thick, scaled torso twists upward with heavy, overlapping ventral plates, finishing in a chaotic cluster of thick, intertwining viper necks.

In the flickering torchlight, the first thing that hits you is the overpowering smell of dung.

Merrshaulk enters the passageway, turning left at the first exit and leading them all deeper into the Fane.

You all enter a small balcony, side-stepping what is a humongous gong with serpentine patterns. An underground cathedral opens below you.

At one end, to your left, a sculptured balcony perches atop five rearing stone serpents. Blood dribbles from the serpents' jaws into a semicircular basin, and from there flows along a sloped trough into a wide stone bowl set into the floor.

South of the blood fountain, to your right, is a mezzanine, promptly situated atop a cauldron of steaming broth. Behind the broth, you see an iron portcullis sealing the entrance to a different chamber.

This place is *packed*. Every single square of space in the Fane is occupied with a Yuan-Ti, who is bowing and hissing in prayer. Standing atop the north balcony, you see is a beautiful, brown-skinned woman with the lower body of a python.

"And now, children of the Coil," The woman speaks. "A feast, to end our prayer today."

You watch a dozen of prisoners marched out from the opposite side. Their eyes are wide and bloodshot.

Intelligence (Investigation) Check
On a successful DC **15** check, Vilde, Raphael and Wukong recognizes that the prisoners are all on kublacaine.



"Listen closely to the rhythm of their hearts," The woman continues. "Hear how fast they beat? That is the pathetic, fluttery panic of warm blood realizing its own end." Cheers and esctatic screams ring out from the crowd. "As we begin our week anew, let their final screams echo into the void, so that the Mother of Nightmares may feed, and we, her chosen, may grow stronger in her shadow."

The prisoners are shoved into the crowd, as the snakefolk surge forward, their fangs unsheathing and tearing the prisoners apart.

Wisdom (Perception) Check

On a successful DC **15** check, Vilde, Raphael and Wukong watches Fenthaza slither away from the balcony onto a stone disk of serpentine design and vanish in a blast of green flame.

"Now, now," Merrshaulk says softly. "Please stay close. If you get grabbed by one of them, just knock them back."

"Who was that?" asks Wukong, leaning close to try to beat the din of the screaming crowd.

"Fenthaza," Merrshaulk explains. "She is our Nightmare Speaker, one of our high priestesses." Without further explanation, the yuan-ti turns, jerking his head. His guards step forward, shoving and pushing the religious gathered here today aside to clear a path. The Party, following Merrshaulk, make their way across the crowded chamber. Upon reaching the other side, Merrshaulk pushes the door open.

Entering this new space, you all recognize this as Ras Nsi's throne room. Four pillars support the vaulted ceiling, and steps ascend to an iron throne carved in the likeness of a hydra. Painted on the wall behind it is a large blue triangle. To the south, an engraved stone disk is set into the floor of an alcove. A ten-foot-wide opening in the east wall leads to a flooded cave.

You see that there is already someone here. A goth-looking woman with pointed teeth and ears. She has a purple beret, a short blazer, black lipstick. Raphael, you recognize this as a half-elf who was born into House Tychonis.

"An elf," Wukong says psychically. "Vilde, do you know her?"

"Do you think all elves know each other?" The rogue replies in her mind. She turns her attention to the person speaking. "Actually..."

Intelligence (History) Check

Failing the DC **15** check, Raphel only recognizes the person as Aelindra Tychonis, the half-elf daughter of Quintus Tychonis.

On a successful DC **15** check, Vilde recognizes the person speaking as the daughter of Jilleniel Alarion, of the Alarion Family, and Quintus Tychonis, of House Tychonis. She recalls that Aelindra is an effort at an alliance between House Tychonis and the Alarion Family, who had been the elven rulers of Syllamere.

Sharing this with the group, Raphael quickly makes the connection. "Her family might have been involved," he

says through the telepathic bond, his psychic voice soft. “In the Senator’s death. Salazar found something on the daggers of the assassins.”



“- and of course, the ships can be here in days,” Aelindra continues her proposal, ignoring the Party’s arrival. “We do not need the bulk of your undead army. My uncle Lord Primus recognizes that you have interests in this continent still. We have plans to raise an undead army of our own on the Eastern coast already. You are simply... our reserves. In the event that we do not have enough.”

“And what do I get in return?” The voice belongs to the yuan-ti reclining on the throne. A thick snake tail covered in dark-red and reddish-brown scales slithers and slides absentmindedly on the ground as the man regards the half-elf with a piercing red eye. The rest of his head is wrapped in bandages; his flesh is decaying and covered in open sores. “I have no need for gold.”

> By Ras Nsi’s side, you see the beautiful brown-skinned woman - the priestess Fenthaza - who was just giving the speech on the balcony. She stands to his right, watching the interaction unfold quietly.

“And what of Alisandra?” Aelindra replies.

Ras Nsi leans forward, hatred and anger burning in his eyes. “What of her?”

“We can save her,” Aelindra continues. “We have already sent our best to study the Death Rider Engine. We believe that we can safely remove her from her prison.”

“And so?” Ras Nsi replies. “What do I want to do with that whore?”

Aelindra smiles. “I’d leave that up to your imagination, my great warlord.”

The yuan-ti leans back in his chest, considering. “Wait upstairs in the Dignitary Suite. I will need the day to consider your proposal.”

She curtsies. “Very well, my lord.”

> As she turns to leave, she spots you, Raphael. She raises an eyebrow in recognition, before winking and exiting the palace.

“And who do we have next?” Ras Nsi asks, waving his hand dismissively.

“The 52nd Expedition,” Fenthaza replies. “They are here with an offer to procure the last puzzle cube.”

> As she finishes her sentence, Vilde, you hear her voice appear as a *Message* in your mind: “*Go with it!*“

“Eh?” Ras Nsi replies. “And for what?”

> “*Say you will destroy the rebel forces in the western quarter,*“ the female yuan-ti’s voice whispers in your ear.

Vilde bows, acknowledging the warlord. Raphael joins her, leaving a puzzled Wukong standing.

“We are offering the last puzzle cube - “ Vilde offers.

“*What?*“ Raphael’s voice was urgent through the

Telepathic Bond. "No!"

"I mean," Vilde corrects herself without so much as a pause. "We are offering to destroy the rebel forces in the west."

"Oh?" Ras Nsi replies. "And how would you do that?"

"We're strong," Vilde says plainly. Wukong enlarges his *Jingubang,* helping to bolster the rogue's point.

"Well, okay, but the problem with crushing the yuan-ti rebellion is not strength," Ras Nsi explains. "They are weak, and useless. The problem is that they are slippery, and hard to find. They hide in hidey-holes and abandoned buildings and launch raids."

"Hard to find?" Vilde asks, thinking. "Watch this." The rogue uncaps her *Eversmoking Bottle* slightly, releasing a small cloud of smoke. As the black smoke dissipates, Vilde is gone.

"What - Where did the elf go - "

"You see?" Appearing behind a nearby pillar, the rogue pops her head out. "It ain't that hard. They will be found."

"Okay, sure," Ras Nsi shrugs. "And what would you ask for, in return?"

"The puzzle cubes," Raphael presses. "Are you in possession of any?"

"Yes, one," Ras Nsi replies. "Acererak asked me to stop adventurers from going into the Tomb of Annihilation, and you need all nine to get in, so I just took one."

"That's what we're asking for," Vilde explains. "The puzzle cube in your possession."

Ras Nsi's single red eye stared unblinkingly into the distance. "Acererak would not want me to give up the cube, though. His wrath for the rebellion... that does not seem like a worthy trade."

"You could accidentally lose it," Wukong offers.

"Our interests are aligned here," the sorcerer steps forward, continuing the conversation. "We're here to help - "

"Where is the cube, anyway?" Vilde asks. "Why don't you just show it to us, so we know you have it?"

Ras Nsi narrows his eye at Vilde, who promptly returned the gesture.

"We can scour the surface and seek out the yuan-ti rebels," Raphael offers. "You know what we want to do; we will scratch your back if you scratch ours - "

"What if I give you gold?" Ras Nsi offers.

"Gold?" Vilde huffs. "We don't need gold."



"I'd love to give you the cube, but you know, on the other hand, Acererak's wrath is... considerable," says Ras Nsi. The warlord leans back, forming a steeple with his hands. "Yes, I'm afraid all I can offer is gold."

"If you're concerned about the rebels, we can deliver them to you," Vilde offers. "Surely taking over Raya is worth more than just gold."

"Well, technically, I have already taken over Raya," Ras Nsi points out. "We control more than half of the city. But all of you are right. The rebels are annoying. I heard something about them setting up a nursery of some kind."

Raphael purses his lips, thinking. Slowly, he said, "Actually... your previous guest. We couldn't help but overhear the conversation you had. I think... we can also be of help."

Ras Nsi leans forward. "And how would you do that?"

"The whore you spoke of..." Raphael trails off, gauging any reaction he could find in the warlord.

"What do you mean?"

"We have seen her," Vilde chimes in, catching on.

"So you've been to the *Heart*?" Ras Nsi asks. "Tell me, then. What colour were her eyes?"

Intelligence (History) Check
On a successful DC **15** check, Raphael and Vilde both remember that Alisandra's eyes were blue.

"Blue," Raphael says plainly.

"Like the sky," encouraged Vilde.

"So you *have* been there," Ras Nsi replies.

"That's not all," Raphael says. "We've also met Arthur."

Ras Nsi spat on the ground. "The little bitch."

Wisdom (Insight) Check
On a successful DC **20** check, Raphael can see that mentioning Arthur has gotten under Ras Nsi's skin. Even as the warlord tries to be nonchalant, the sorcerer can see an undercurrent of rage and hatred that spans centuries under Ras Nsi's even tone.

"Kill him," Ras Nsi says flatly. "Bring me his head, and I'll give you the puzzle cube."

"We know where he is," Vilde says slowly. "We can bring him here. Don't you want to deal the killing blow?"

Wukong nods. "The last time we saw him, he was quite weak already."

Charisma (Persuasion) Check
On a successful DC **20** check, Vilde convinces Ras Nsi to duel Arthur Cimber, here in the Fane, instead.

"Okay," Ras Nsi says. "Bring him here, and I'll give you the cube." The warlord cocks his head, thinking. "And you know what? I think it will be exciting if we make this a little competition. I will present the same terms to Aelindra. I will accept the offer of whoever gets him here first."

Vilde hears Fenthaza urgently whisper again in her mind. "*Stop making it so complicated! Just tell him you'll destroy the rebels*!" Pushing the *Message* aside, Vilde continues, "And in the meantime, if we destroy the rebel forces, would you just give us the cube - "

"No, no, no," Ras Nsi laughs, a devilish smile creeping up on his face. "This is as much entertainment as I have had in years. Bring Arthur here. And if you succeed in that endeavor, then I accept your offer."

"*It's not working,*" Vilde fires back in her mind towards Fenthaza. "*He does not care as much for the rebels. What else do you have?*"

"*Meet me in my chambers, please,*" Fenthaza implores.

The warlord claps his hands together, signalling the end of the conference. "Alright, that's it."

"And the rebels?" Raphael asks. "You have shown good faith. If you want us to help you crush... these insects, we are happy to."

"Oh, yes," Ras Nsi explains. "This race to find Arthur is but a simple clause in our deal. Get him, and I'll accept your proposal: the death of the rebels, for the cube. The same terms go out to Aelindra. If she gets him, then she gets the pleasure of leasing my undead army. Now, is business concluded?"

"Yes, my great warlord," Fenthaza speaks up. "I think it would be wise if the resources of the Fane were offered to both parties. They could gather the strength they need for this imposing task from the armoury. I would, of course, also head upstairs and let Aelindra know of this new development."

Ras Nsi merely grunted a sound of approval, waving his hand dismissively.

"All this for one cube," Vilde grumbles psychically. "This seems inefficient."

"We could also just storm the place and kill everyone here," Raphael suggests through the *Telepathic Bond*.

"Or we could also just plan a heist," Wukong offers. "It has been a while since I stole something from a vault..."

Fenthaza leads the group towards the back of the throne room, bringing Vilde, Raphael, Wukong and Vorn towards a serpentine stone disk. As she does so, the Party continues discussing their next course of action telepathically.

"He's scared of Acererak," Raphael warns. "And yet, I think he's willing to risk it all for the chance of killing the one man who cuckolded him all those years ago."

"Man's unconvinceable," Vilde complains.

"Well at least we got him to accept us bringing Arthur here alive," Wukong points out. "If not, we would likely have had to fight the man... At least now, we can bring Arthur here alive and turn on Ras Nsi."

In a blast of green flame, all five of you are engulfed. As the fire fades, you find yourself in a small, cramped room. The stench of sweat fills the humid air. To your left and right, you see four pits with circular iron grates covering them. A chain hooked to each grate stretches over a pulley bolted to the ceiling and coils around an iron winch set into the nearby walls. Iron manacles dangle from hooks.

"Our prisoner pits," Fenthaza explained. "Don't mind us, it's the closest one to my chambers... Sometimes I think Ras Nsi did this on purpose, having my closest disk be the ones in the cells..." The priestess slithers out. Guards in the corridor outside nod, pulling a lever. With a rattling sound, the iron portcullis is lifted.

Passing by the pits, Raphael hears muffled moans from one of the holes. Looking down, he sees a face he recognizes - Ejiro, the other guide the 52nd Expedition had interviewed almost a month ago. Dressed in a grey sack and chained, the guide hangs her head in dispair in the partially flooded pit.

"*It's Ejiro!*" Raphael shares with the rest of the group. "*The other guide we sought, back in Port M'Kaze.*"

"I can't help but notice you have a prisoner in there," Vilde asks tentatively as the group make their way down the well-lit hallway. "Why crime did she commit?"

"Oh, she's one of the rebels," Fenthaza says flatly.

The two guards stand at attention as you all approach Fenthaza's chambers. She slithers right on in, ignoring the pair.

A haze of incense lingers inside this room. Throw rugs and plush, feathered cushions lie scattered on the floor, with an engraved chest in the corner next to a stone urn covered with snake carvings.

"Why didn't you just offer to destroy the rebels?" Fenthaza protested in the safety of her quarters.

"He didn't seem convinced," Vilde says evenly. "We had to offer a bigger carrot. Six was not enough... he needed the nine inch."

"Sorry?"

Raphael and Wukong suppressed a chuckle.

"He wasn't going to give up the cube," Raphael says dismissively. "Eliminating the rebel forces wasn't enough."

"Sure?" Fenthaza said. "But okay, listen. You guys won't have to do any of that. I asked all of you here because I want you to kill him. Kill him, and *I* will give you the cube."

As she says this, it clicks in your minds almost instantly: back at the Commanders' Tent, Merrshaulk had said that 'Ras Nsi wanted to make the Expedition an offer,' only for Ras Nsi to ask all of you what you had to offer when you all had an audience with him. You realize that she was the one who brought all of you into the Fane.



"Why do you want to kill him?" Vilde asks.

"Because he's an idiot," Fenthaza says, rolling her eyes. "First of all, he's not a real yuan-ti. Did you know that?"

Raphael and Vilde nods quietly.

"He was an elf, or a human, or something back in the day," Fenthaza explains. "He was half-dead when the patrols found him, several centuries ago. The Nightmare Speaker back then pulled him back from the brink of death by turning him into a yuan-ti, saving his life. But despite so, he never really embraced our culture. He is not a *true* yuan-ti. He never was." Fenthaza slithers over to her pillows, curling up into a lounge. "Beyond all that, he is setting us up to work with Acererak. The lich is a blight on the world, not to mention evil."

Nods of assent rose from the group.

"We agree," Wukong says.

"We are here for one purpose, and one purpose only," Fenthaza continued. "To summon the Night Serpent and destroy the world. It's as simple as that. I don't understand why can't he just do that - "

As she says this, all of you see violent, dark murals decorating the walls of her quarters. You see red skies, black lands choked with ash, and a giant snake rising from the ground and eating the people.

Wisdom (Perception) Check

On a successful DC **20** check, Raphael you see a sense of frustration from the yuan-ti and can intuit that Fenthaza, believing that Ras Nsi is a horrendous fit as the leader of the yuan-ti, has probably been trying to get rid of Ras Nsi for the better part of her time as the Nightmare Speaker. You suspect that it is likely that she was the one who wants to quash the rebellion and control all the yuan-ti.

On a successful DC **25** check, you see some correspondence on her desk that you can freely pocket.

"*Oh,*" Vilde says, silently in the Party's *Telepathic Bond.* "*I guess everyone here is crazy.*" The rogue does not miss a beat. She asks out loud, "Who here, in the Fane, is on your side, and who is on his side?"

"It's tough," Fenthaza says, rubbing her forehead. "The devout adherents of the Night Serpent are on my side, but Ras Nsi is powerful. Those in his harem are of course loyal to him, and then there's the undead. He is a proficient necromancer."

"How do we know which of the yuan-ti are in his harem?" asks Vilde.

"Back in the Fane - the chamber with the blood fountain where we do our rites - there's a portcullis," She explains. "They're in there most of the time, but they do leave for business from time to time." She pauses briefly, thinking. "I'm not sure if it will help, but apparently one of them is sleeping with the royal guard."

"And how many are there?" Wukong asks.

"Three," Fenthaza explains. "One of them has the head of a purple cobra, and a female humanoid body. The rest of them look like me, but are a little more white in their skin tones - "

"We don't see color," Vilde says quickly. "When do you suggest we strike?"

"Yeah, maybe while he's copulating with the harem," Wukong suggests.

"He visits them at all hours," Fenthaza replies. "But, I think striking during the day would be wise. Of course, the palace will be guarded at all times, but we are nocturnal by nature. There would be less defenders by day."

"Any weaknesses?" Wukong asks.

"No, not particularly," the priestess replies. "The teleportation disks, those are a potential problem. He installed them. Any attempt on his life needs to be quick; if he escapes to any one of the disks, he will be able to move to a different part of the Fane and potentially slip free. Aside from that, nothing specific. He is immune to poison, from years of conditioning."

"Could we break the disks?" Vilde asks. "Or move them somehow?"

"I haven't figured out a way to," Fenthaza confesses. "They're engraved into the ground, so they cannot be moved as well."

"If we attack," Wukong asks. "Could you marshal your followers to attack his? As a diversion of some sort."

Vilde nods. "Engage his people, so we can isolate him. Stop reinforcements."

Raphael suppressed a quick smile. *It's not our first revolution,* he thought.

"Of course," Fenthaza said. "Take your time, explore the Fane. Once you have a plan of some sort, let me know."

"We might have to isolate him, somehow," Raphael suggested. "If he thinks we have Arthur... maybe we could get him alone?"

"A trap," Vilde nods. "But, wait a minute. How do we know you know where's the puzzle cube?"

"Oh, that's easy," Fenthaza says. "The cube's in his



chambers. I'll take the cube for all of you, once he's dead."

"We need to confer with our allies," Vilde points out. "Do we have to stay here this whole time?"

Fenthaza shakes her head. "You are free to leave whenever you wish. I just asked him to extend the Fane's hospitality in the event that you wish to scout and map out the interior of the Fane."

"We do want to case the place," Raphael agrees. "We will head out once we study the layout."

"The cave," Wukong asks, just as the Party prepares to head out into the Fane of the Night Serpent. "Do you know where that leads to?"

"It's the back entrance," Fenthaza explains. "He has a hydra in there... so be careful."

"Oh," Vilde says, raising an eyebrow. "That ain't good."

Fenthaza nods. "The other option is to go *through* the Fane, which is the rest of the yuan-ti."

Vilde nods, thinking.

The priestess produces a *Sending Stone,* passing it over to the rogue. "Let me know if you need anything else."

The Fane of the Night Serpent

Deciding it would be quicker to map the Fane by splitting up, Vilde, Wukong and Raphael decide to explore separately.

Walking into this place, Vilde you see that the walls of this pillared hall bear murals of a giant serpent and yuan-ti worshipers doing terrible things, much like Fenthaza's room. You see the yuan-ti terrorizing the Rayans, as well as a yuan-ti - Ras Nsi - wielding a flaming sword and a gold crown set with a black opal leading the snake people to a great door.

Wisdom (Perception) Check
On a successful DC **20** check, Vilde you see that the balack opal in the crown is a stone button. You also see, running along the scales of the Night Serpent depicted in the mural are tiny holes. You suspect that it is a trap of some kind.

Noting the trap, Vilde leaves the Hall of Serpents and head towards the Armory.

Moving forward, you find yourself at an imposing steel door. Hanging from it, slightly askew, is a wooden sign in Common: *Armoury.*

Vilde resets the sign, setting it straight before fishing out her *Thieves' Tools.*

Unlocking the door, you see gleaming scimitars, serpent helms, and suits of scale armor cramming the racks of this vault. Large bones and horned skulls litter the floor, and a shield made from the shell of a tortoise hangs on the far wall.

A large skeletal serpent slithers out from behind the racks, raising its head. It whispers in a raspy voice: "They will tell us the passphrase! The passphrase!"

"Uh," Vilde says, stepping backwards. She fishes out her *Sending Stone,* contacting Fenthaza.

"You didn't tell us the passphrase! What's the passphrase for the armory? I need it now!"

"Why are you at the armory?" Fenthaza asks, exasperated. "I said 'explore the Fane,' not 'go to the armory!'; that's just what you're supposed to tell people if - "

Rolling her eyes, Vilde struggles not to laugh. "Okay, you know what," Vilde hisses, trying to mimic the skeletal snake. "Ssssalazar?"

"They will tell us the correct passphrase!"

"Um, Ras Nsi sent us here to prepare for him," the rogue explains. "And he forgot to tell us the passphrase."

Psychically, the doors swing shut. With a resounding lock, the skeletal serpent return to her business inside the armory, leaving the elf alone in the corridor.

Wanting to make sure the skeletal serpent stays locked in, Vilde steps up and jams the lock, sealing the monster inside the armory.

Wukong. Entering the room beside Fenthaza's quarters with Vorn, you see steam rising from a stone basin. It is filled with a clear, blue liquid. Three serpentine creatures swim in the pool below; each has the head and upper body of a bald dark-skinned woman and the lower body of a snake.

"Hi, sorry to disturb," Wukong says gently. "But, uh, what room is this?"

With supernatural speed, all three bald-headed women burst from the surface, their white eyes regarding the paladin.

"I, uh, think I got lost," Wukong tries.

"You are in the Room of the Evil Oracle," the three speak in unison.

"Okay, cool," Wukong says. "Wrong room, so we're just going to... head on out of here." The paladin walks backward, never taking his eyes off them as he exits the room.

Raphael. Heading back to the prisoner pits, you cut through the sacrificial chamber that you all had just walked past. A bloodstained altar stands in the middle of this room, with shackles bolted to its top and niches carved into its side. Grooves run down the altar to gutters on the floor, intended for spilled blood to drain into the walls.

Re-entering the cells, the two guards nod at you before lifting the portcullis. You step up to where you know Ejiro is held, looking down and whispering.

"Ejiro?" Raphael asks. Up close, without makeup, it was easy to see her scales.

Ejiro roused from her restless sleep. "Who are you?"

"The 52nd Expedition," Raphael offers. "We met, back in Port M'Kaze. Some of my Party members interviewed you, and tried to recruit you."

She raised an eyebrow. "People interview me all the time. Could you be a little more specific?"

"Why are you down here?"

"I'm a prisoner," Ejiro explains. "They caught me sneaking in and trying to kill Ras Nsi."

"Alone?"

She shook her head. "I was actually with a friend, Nessa, but we got caught. We shapeshifted into snakes - that's what the gap in the base of the front door was for - but they were waiting for us. She managed to make it out, but I didn't."

Raphael nods. "I can't get you out now, but we might be able to help. When I return, we should be able to free you."

"You're leaving the Fane?"

"Yeah," Raphael says.

"If you can, could you get a message to Nessa?" Ejiro asks. "We'll pay you."

"Sure," Raphael replies. "If I see her, I will give her the message."

"Tell her I'm still alive," Ejiro explains. "And that Kakarol might be able to help us with Ras Nsi, so we should get the kobolds on our side. Tell her that I've heard there is a secret back entrance of some kind, and that the next attempt should be through the underground lake. The only thing she'll have to worry about coming from there is the hydra."

Raphael nods, firing a warning to Vilde. "We will take all this back," he promises.

"You *are* actually going to do that, right? You're not just going to ignore it, right?"

The sorcerer pauses, thinking. "My intelligence has told me she's in the western quarter with the rest of the rebels, right?"

Ejiro nods. "The kobolds are hiding in the bazaar. As for Nessa... I think she'd might be in the Nursery."

"Is there a passcode or passphrase of any kind?" Raphael asks tentatively. "I'd hate to walk directly into an enemy attack."

"Tell her 'the red moon sets tonight'," Ejiro says. "That will let her know."

The trio, with Vorn, gather by the armory, quickly sharing what they found.

Wukong, you split off down the diagonal corridor, eventually finding yourself in front of a double door. With a soft push, you open the door and see a storeroom. Stacks of sturdy wood crates, bundles of cloth and clay amphorae litter the floor. There is a giant constrictor snake in the room who seems to be sleeping. As you enter, the snake snaps awake, rearing its head.

"What? Who's there?"

"Hi," Wukong offers. "I must have taken a wrong turn."

"Who are you? What are you doing here?"

Wisdom (Perception) Check

On a successful DC **15** check, Wukong is able to ascertain the contents of the crates in this room; fifty bolts of cloth, six crates of bronze bars, three barrels of salts and spices. He gathers that they can assemble enough gear to make five explorer's packs.

In addition, two of the crates are strangely sealed. One of the crates is labelled 'kublacaine'; the other is labelled 'incense.'

"The warlord sent me," Wukong lies. "He told me that I'm free to walk around, and head to the armory, but uh... this isn't it, right?"

"No, no, this is the storeroom," the giant constrictor snake hisses, shaking its head. "That's on the left. Head back down the hallway and take the first left."

"Thanks," Wukong smiles. "And, also, just out of curiosity, what's that behind you?"

"Kublacaine," the snake explains. "We need it for our rituals."

"And how did you get it?" Wukong asks. "Raya isn't exactly a trading hub, is it?"

"The Xanathar Network delivers it," the snake offers, yawning. "Is that all?"

"Yes, that's all," Wukong offers. "I'll be on my way."

The giant constrictor snake rests its head on itself once again, falling asleep.

Mesmerising Incense

Lighting a block of temple incense creates a hazy cloud that fills a 20-foot-diameter sphere that moves with the block. Any creature that starts its turn in the cloud and breathes the air must succeed on a DC 16 Constitution saving throw or fall into a dream-like stupor laced with nightmarish visions. Though it remains awake, the creature is Poisoned. The effect lasts for an hour after a creature leaves the cloud, or until it receives a *Lesser Restoration* spell or similar magic.

Vilde skulks the dark doorways, entering a small distillery.

The air in here is moist and sticky. Natural light spils from cracks in the ceiling, and mud coats the floor. Stone workbenches are laden with clay bottles of various colors, shapes and sizes. Toadstools, snakeroot, and belladonna plants grow among the clutter, fed by water seeping from above. Standing near the plants is a hairless man with scaly skin and a bronze syringe. Lurking in the shadows around him are five slouching humans reeking of decay.

Wisdom (Perception) Check

On a successful DC **15** check, Vilde spies a key on the belt of the hairlessman. She also sees the bottles of poison all over the workbenches, all of which look incredibly combustible.

The rogue stealthily heads back, intending to share her discoveries with the rest.

Heading west, Raphael, you see a rickety wooden walkway threading around the walls of a deep pit. Foul odors waft up from below. Somewhere in the gloom beneath you, thousands of snake writhe.

Treading lightly, Raphael places his weight testily onto the wooden walkway. Certain that it could take him, the sorcerer moves forward quietly.

The iron stench of blood floods your nostrils as you enter this new chamber. Along one wall, a row of gore-filled pools sink into the floor. Blood trails and bloody footprints run between the pools.

Two yuan-ti slither past Raphael, heading into the chamber. Wordlessly, they begin to disrobe.

It's a shower, Raphael realizes.



Wukong and Vilde, having finished with their rooms, slink towards the snake pit. Finding Raphael in the shower, the trio quickly catch each other up of their discoveries.

"Woah, woah! What are you doing here?" One of the disrobed yuan-ti shouts, his hands slick with blood. "This is a men's toilet!"

"Oh sorry!" Vilde rushes back out of the shower, covering her eyes.

"We should wrap things up," Raphael points out. "We just got to find the back entrance..."

Raphael and Wukong head deeper into the baths, trying to find a way to break out to the south.

Entering this room, heat rises from an enormous oval stone set into the floor of this chamber. Discarded skins heap around it, and shelves underneath it are lined with jars.

"A sauna," Wukong realizes. "They are living the high life."

A snake-headed yuan-ti, fully nude, is in the room, shedding his skin.

Raphael nods.

Stumbling away, Vilde you slam yourself into an unlocked set of double doors and find yourself in what used to be a catacomb. Since the yuan-ti takeover, these dank catacombs have been converted into sleeping quarters. The walls here are lined with alcoves that now serve as nests.

Finding a door beyond the nest, Vilde stealthily inches forward, careful not to disturb the sleeping yuan-ti. She opens it to find an underground river, which she surmises would likely lead to the back entrance.

With most of the Fane visited, the trio gathers together once again.

"The incense might be useful," Wukong offers.

"I'll grab it," Vilde says. "And we can try to get through the storeroom to the door behind. It's likely that will lead to the secret entrance."

The rogue sneaks back into the storeroom, pocketing a block of mesmerizing incense along the way. She fishes out her Thieves' Tools, silently unlocking it.

As the door swings open, Vilde you find yourself in a grott. A campfire casts warm light over this cavern, with heaps of dead grass and palm fronds scattered about. The muddy floor here is pitted with footprints.

You can spy about 13 slaves in here, swinging pickaxes of some kind at the stone.

Dexterity (Stealth) Check

On a successful DC **25** check, Vilde is undetected by the Slavemaster.

Silently jerking her head, the rogue leads Raphael, Wukong and Vorn out through the back entrance.